THE BUCK $TARTS HERE

Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 7 — Partners & Sustainability

Student Course Companion

Name: ______________________________ Organization: ____________________________________

Team / Cohort (if applicable): ____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 7. Two sections — partners and sustainability — but two sections that carry real weight in a funder's decision. Complete each section in order. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 7. Review them before moving into the exercises.

Partner	An organization with a defined, specific, committed role in the delivery of your program. Not just an organization that likes what you do — one that shows up with a concrete contribution.
Supporter	An organization or individual that wishes you well but has no specific, committed role in program delivery. A supporter is not the same as a partner — and funders know the difference.
Partner Contribution	What a partner organization is actually bringing to your program — in-kind space, staff time, financial resources, client referrals, training, equipment, or expertise. Must be named and quantified.
Letter of Support	A signed document from a partner organization confirming their specific commitment to your program. Must name the program, describe the partner's role in concrete terms, and be signed by an authorized representative. Generic letters of goodwill are not the same thing.
New vs. Established Partnership	A distinction funders need to know. An established partnership has a track record. A new one is a commitment being made for

	this project. Both are valid — but transparency is required. Funders do not appreciate discovering that a “partnership” was a phone call last week.
Sustainability Plan	A specific, written description of how your program will continue after the grant period ends. Names funders you will pursue, government relationships you are building, earned revenue strategies, and projected dollar amounts. A hope is not a plan.
Current Funding Base	The existing sources of revenue your organization relies on. Described in the sustainability section to show funders that you are not a single-source organization. Diversity of revenue = lower perceived risk.
Earned Revenue	Income generated by your organization through fees for service, program tuition, product sales, or other activities not dependent on charitable contributions. A component of many strong sustainability plans.
Government Contract / Partnership	A formal or in-progress agreement with a government agency to deliver services in exchange for funding. Often cited in sustainability plans as a source of ongoing support.
Catalytic Investment	A framing for the funder’s grant as the starting point that enables future funding — not the permanent solution. Use this frame when you can explain how their investment positions you for the next phase of growth or funding.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated proposal excerpts below. The right column explains what each element is doing and why it works. As you read, identify which techniques your own proposal currently uses and which ones need strengthening.

Sample: Partner Description and Sustainability Plan

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
[PARTNER DESCRIPTION] *Jefferson Unified School District (JUSD) is a long-standing partner of Community Works. JUSD will*	**→ Established partnership named and confirmed** **→ Contribution is specific: 5**

provide dedicated classroom space at Roosevelt Middle School for program sessions five evenings per week at no cost to the project — an in-kind contribution valued at approximately $18,000 annually. In addition, JUSD has committed a credentialed school counselor for six hours per month to co-facilitate our academic support workshops. A letter of support from the JUSD Superintendent is included in the attachments. *Valley Health Clinic is a new partner for this project. Although we have not previously collaborated formally, Valley Health has reviewed our program design and committed to providing free mental health screenings for all enrolled participants at program entry and exit — a service valued at $12,000 — as well as referral pathways for participants requiring ongoing clinical support.*	**evenings/week, dollar value quantified ($18,000)** **→ Staff commitment quantified: 6 hrs/month, role named** **→ Letter of support referenced — funder knows to look for it** **→ New partnership acknowledged transparently** **→ Contribution still quantified ($12,000) even for a new partner**
[SUSTAINABILITY PLAN] *Community Works currently receives funding from four sources: the Hartwell Foundation ($80,000), the County Department of Health ($55,000), individual donors ($28,000), and earned revenue through our sliding-scale workshop fees ($14,000). No single source represents more than 45% of our operating budget.* *Following the initial grant period, we will sustain this program through three channels. First, we will apply to the Morrison Family Foundation and the Civic Progress Fund, both of which have funded comparable youth workforce programs in our region. Second, we are in active conversation with the County Workforce Development Board about a performance-based contract beginning in program year two, which we project could generate $40,000–$60,000 annually. Third, we are piloting a sliding-scale participant fee for families above 200% of the federal poverty line, which we conservatively project will generate $10,000 in year two and $18,000 in year three.*	**→ Current funding base described first: four sources named** **→ No single source dominates — 45% cap signals diversification** **→ Three specific sustainability channels named — not vague intentions** **→ Government partnership described as “active conversation” — honest, not overstated** **→ Earned revenue projections include specific years and dollar amounts**

 Team: *As a group: walk through the sustainability example. Which of your organization’s current revenue sources would you list in your funding base? Are there any sources that represent more than 50% of your budget? What does that mean for your proposal?*

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what wins funding. Answer the reflection question after each pair.

Comparison 1 — Partner Description

Weak	**Strong**
We are partnering with the local school district and a community health organization to support program participants. Both organizations are excited about our work and have agreed to collaborate.	*The Jefferson Unified School District will provide dedicated classroom space at Roosevelt Middle School for five evenings per week at no cost to the program — an in-kind contribution valued at $18,000 annually — and will assign a credentialed school counselor to co-facilitate our academic workshops for six hours per month. A letter of support from the JUSD Superintendent is included in the attachments.*

What specific information does the strong version include that the weak version omits entirely?

Team discussion: *List your organization's genuine partners — not supporters, partners. For each one, write down exactly what they contribute. If you cannot describe a specific contribution, they are a supporter, not a partner.*

Comparison 2 — Letter of Support Guidance

Weak	**Strong**
We have letters of support from several community organizations who believe in our mission and are excited to see this program succeed in our community.	*Letters of support from Jefferson Unified School District, Valley Health Clinic, and the Downtown Business Improvement District are included in the attachments. Each letter confirms the partner's specific commitment to this program — including facility access, staff*

	time, and financial contribution — and is signed by the respective executive director or superintendent.

What is the difference between a strong letter of support and a letter of goodwill? What should you tell your partners before they write their letters?

Team discussion: *Draft a one-paragraph briefing document your team could send to partner organizations explaining what the grant is for, what their specific role is, and what the letter should confirm.*

Comparison 3 — Sustainability Plan

Weak	Strong
We are committed to the long-term sustainability of this program and will seek additional funding sources as they become available. We believe strongly in the importance of this work and will work hard to ensure it continues.	*Following the grant period, we will sustain this program through three channels: applications to the Morrison Family Foundation and the Civic Progress Fund (both of which fund comparable programs in our region); a performance-based contract with the County Workforce Development Board currently in negotiation, projected to generate $40,000–$60,000 annually; and a sliding-scale participant fee for families above 200% of the federal poverty line, projected to generate $18,000 by year three.*

What three things does the strong sustainability plan name that the weak version does not?

Team discussion: *As a group, list every real conversation your organization is currently having about future funding. Name the funder, the agency, or the revenue strategy. That list is the raw material for your sustainability section.*

Comparison 4 — Current Funding Base

Weak	Strong
Our organization has a diverse funding base that includes grants, donations, and other sources of revenue.	*Community Works currently receives funding from four sources: the Hartwell Foundation ($80,000 / 40% of budget), the County Department of Health ($55,000 / 28%), individual donors ($28,000 / 14%), and earned revenue from sliding-scale workshop fees ($14,000 / 7%). An additional $20,000 (11%) is projected from a new corporate sponsor currently in the final stages of commitment.*

What does a specific, quantified funding base description communicate to a funder that a vague one does not?

Team discussion: *Complete the Funding Base Table in Section 4 as a team. Is any single source over 50% of your budget? If so, what are you doing to reduce that concentration?*

Section 4 — Your Proposal Builder

Complete each part below. This is the raw material for your partners and sustainability sections. Be as specific as possible — vague answers here become weak proposal sections later.

Part A — Your Partner Map

Complete the table for every organization with a genuine, specific role in your program. Supporters do not belong in this table.

Partner Organization	Their Mission / Role	Specific Contribution (Quantify)	New or Established?	Letter of Support?

Tip: *For in-kind contributions, calculate the fair market value. Space has a rental value. Staff time has an hourly rate. Equipment has a purchase or rental value. Quantifying in-kind contributions shows funders the full scope of community investment in your program.*

Choose your most important partner. Write a full 3–4 sentence description for your proposal: who they are, what they contribute (quantified), whether the partnership is new or established, and whether a letter of support will be included.

Team discussion: *Assign each partner organization to a team member to confirm their commitment and request a letter of support. Set a deadline. A partner who will not provide a letter may not be as committed as you think.*

Part B — Letter of Support Briefing

Before your partners write their letters, brief them on what the letter needs to include. Use the prompts below to draft a briefing message you can share with each partner.

Grant name and funder:

What this grant will fund (one sentence):

This partner's specific role in the program:

What their letter should confirm (contribution, timeline, contact name for follow-up):

★Example — Letter of support briefing language:
Dear [Partner Name], we are submitting a proposal to [Funder] requesting $[amount] to fund [program name]. Your organization's role in this program is [specific role]. We are asking you to provide a one-page letter on your organization's letterhead confirming your commitment to [specific contribution], signed by [title]. If you have questions, please contact [name] at [phone/email] by [date].

Part C — Your Current Funding Base

Complete the table below with your organization's current revenue sources. Be honest and specific.

Revenue Source	Funder / Source Name	Annual Amount ($)	% of Total Budget
Foundation Grants			
Government Contracts / Grants			
Individual Donors			
Corporate Sponsors			
Earned Revenue / Fees			
In-Kind Contributions			
Other:			

Tip: *If any single source represents more than 50% of your budget, address it directly in your sustainability section. Tell the funder what steps you are actively taking to diversify. Transparency is more credible than concealment.*

Team: *Review the completed table together. What does your funding base tell a funder about your organization's financial stability? What would you want to change about it before your next submission cycle?*

Part D — Your Sustainability Plan

- **Funder 1 you plan to pursue for continued funding (name, why they are a fit):**

- **Funder 2 you plan to pursue for continued funding (name, why they are a fit):**

☐ **Government partnership or contract you are exploring (agency, status of conversation):**

☐ **Earned revenue strategy (fee for service, sliding-scale, product, etc.) and projected annual amount:**

☐ **Is this grant itself part of a larger sustainability strategy? If so, how does it position you for the next phase? (e.g., building infrastructure, generating outcome data, establishing a model)**

☐ **Draft your full sustainability paragraph using the above answers. Name specific funders, describe government partnerships in progress, and include projected revenue figures.**

☐ **Team discussion:** *Read your sustainability paragraphs aloud as a group. Does each one sound like a plan or a hope? Replace any vague language ("we will seek additional funding") with a specific named strategy.*

★**Example — Sustainability paragraph structure:**

Our organization currently receives funding from [sources]. Following the grant period, we will sustain this program through three channels: first, applications to [Funder A] and [Funder B], both of which have funded comparable programs in our region; second, a [government agency] contract currently in [stage] that we project will generate $[amount] annually beginning in year [X]; and third, a [revenue model] that we conservatively project will generate $[amount] by year [X].

Section 5 — Module 7 Self-Audit Checklist

Check every box you can honestly say is true for your current proposal draft. Unchecked boxes are revision priorities.

Partners

- □ Every organization I describe as a partner has a specific, committed, named role in program delivery — not just general goodwill.
- □ For each partner, I have named what they contribute and quantified it where possible (hours, dollar value, frequency).
- □ I have noted whether each partnership is new or established and been transparent about the difference.
- □ I have requested letters of support from each partner and briefed them on what the letter needs to confirm.
- □ My partner descriptions are consistent with what the letters of support will say.

Letters of Support

- □ Each letter of support names the specific program it is supporting — not just my organization in general.
- □ Each letter describes the partner's specific commitment in concrete terms.
- □ Each letter is signed by an authorized representative (executive director, superintendent, agency head).
- □ Letters from all named partners will be included in the attachments.

Current Funding Base

- □ I have described my current revenue sources by name, amount, and percentage of total budget.
- □ No single source represents more than 50% of my operating budget — or if it does, I have addressed this directly in my sustainability section.
- □ My funding base description gives the funder confidence that I am not a one-revenue organization.

Sustainability Plan

- ◻ My sustainability section names at least two specific funders I will pursue after the grant period.
- ◻ I have described any government relationships or contracts in progress — with the agency named and the status of the conversation noted.
- ◻ I have included at least one earned revenue strategy with a projected dollar amount and timeline.
- ◻ I have not used vague language like "we will seek additional funding" without naming what that funding is.
- ◻ If this grant is part of a larger sustainability strategy, I have explained how it positions us for the next phase.

Coherence

- ◻ My partner descriptions are consistent with the program activities I described in Module 6.
- ◻ My sustainability plan reflects a realistic understanding of my organization's current funding base and capacity.
- ◻ Everything in this module is consistent with the needs, goals, and population I described in Modules 5 and 6.

My revision priorities before the next module:

◻ **Team:** *Assign each revision item a team member and a due date. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.*

"You don't build trust with a funder by having all the answers.
You build it by showing them you've asked the right questions
and are actively working toward the answers."